Europeans doing nothing of these.[174]

One other origin of Eastern European populism in their view is a ‘delayed backlash against several decades of identity-denial politics, otherwise known as Westernisation, which began in 1989’.[175] In that respect they are critical of the fact that the West has forgotten that ‘liberalism, too, works best within the context of politically bounded communities’.[176]

Indeed, a number of Western European countries have seen their national cohesion tested in recent years, from the UK in the case of Scottish aspirations to independence to Spain in the case of Catalonia. And in the US, polarisation of society has reached such an extent that – particularly following the 6 January riots – there was talk about the possibility of a civil war.

As in the West, meritocracy, as one of the essential foundations of Western civilisation, began to show its drawbacks in the East too, even if it manifested itself differently. Here, ‘meritocracy is additionally offensive in the region’s historical context because of the privileged access to economic success provided, after 1989, to those who occupied important political positions in the previous oppressive system. What distinguished 1989 from all previous revolutions was the ease with which the ostensibly “dethroned” elites managed to preserve their power and influence.’[177] This is the legacy of the old-boys network, of former regime apparatchiks. While (in Poland and Hungary) this may indeed serve as an excuse for a simple power-grab, it is – in the eyes of conservative voters – a real problem in Slovenia, where the former elite managed to maintain a fair degree of legitimacy by opting for the country’s independence and by showing the will to transform, at least on the surface, early on in the transition process. Their dominance appears to be so overwhelming that it largely goes unnoticed by those on the same side of the divide. As one of the leading left-wing national TV commentators Marcel Štefančič said in a rare moment of acknowledgement, at the height of the campaign against right-wing Prime Minister Janša’s attempts to have a more balanced national TV broadcaster by promoting journalists closer to Mr Janša: ‘There are fuc**** more of us than them. They are only a few and we know exactly who they are.’[178] Soon after that, Janša was voted out of office in a landslide victory by a political novice Robert Golob who became Prime Minister in June 2022 and announced his intention to depoliticise the media and public administration, with expert